

Westhampton Finance Committee Meeting
April 19, 2016

Meeting opened at 7:00 pm in the Library

Present: Thomas Cleary (interim chair), Ed Zawacki, Maryanne Duggan, Jackie Brodeur, Aniko Giordano, Ellice Gonzalez Brandow, Celeste Whiting, Joe Pipczynski, and Chevy Seney.

Also in Attendance: Joe Boudreau and Steve Gagne

Revisions to minutes of April 12, 2016 are as follow: “Police Department may have **\$2000.**” Omit second sentence of paragraph four, “Since the close of the budget year does not....” Jackie will make these changes and forward the revised minutes to Cheryl and cc to fellow members.

Motion to accept revised minutes of April 12, 2016 approved. 6-0-0

Old Business

Tom shared a draft of the historical town budget numbers to be distributed in the Town Report. Members discussed whether this historical reference sheet would need a note of clarification. The Committee will ultimately make this decision at the next meeting.

A motion containing several components was made.

- I. Any individual providing services and receiving payment from the Town in an amount of \$1,000 or greater will receive a 1.5% increase in FY17.
- II. Any individual providing services and receiving payment from the Town in an amount less than \$1,000 will be “level funded” in FY17.
- III. Line 3 Moderator, Line 47 Memorial Day, and Line 48 Cultural Council will be lowered to \$ 0 in FY17.

Discussion included concern for the perception of “zeroing out” some Lines while leaving others intact, specifically Line 65 and Line 71. The committee ultimately agreed that the context for funding these Lines was “anachronistic.” In the past funding for these Lines was linked to accessing insurance which is no longer the case. Joe B. shared

information regarding the funds in Line 48. He is aware that these monies **are** being used.

Amendment to the motion removing Line 48 from the initial motion was approved 8-0-0. All three components of the amended motion passed 9-0-0

After examining the most recent Cherry Sheets, Tom believes the proposed budget is “off” by ~\$25,000. The ensuing discussion revolved around using Free Cash to balance the FY17 Budget. There was also concern that at TM people would want to use more Free Cash to lower the tax rate. Free Cash needs to be maintained for capital projects. If it goes too low, Bonding/Rating Agencies would perhaps be concerned, according to Joe B. Members of the Committee would like to change Line 131 to read “Free Cash Reduce Tax Rate **and Balance Budget.**” There is concern that using Free Cash continually to balance the budget is not good planning. **There is no line for Stabilization Fund on the proposed Budget.** Where did it go?

Joe B. commented that last year’s audit indicated that the Stabilization Fund was low.

Joe P. proposed using \$15,000 in Line 131 for FY17.

Further discussion focused on the Article to raise capital (\$30,000) as a one-time exclusion to paint Town Hall. **The Committee would like the S.B. to be aware that Line 99 is “contingent upon the passage of the override.”**

What follows is the record of the votes on the Lines in the April 13th Town of Westhampton Proposed Budget FY 2017 in which Line 137 reads “\$24,929.00”

Lines 1-10	Hold Line 3	Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 11-20		Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 21-30		Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 31-40	Hold Line 40	Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 41-50	Hold Line 41	
	Hold Line 47	Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 51-60		Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 61-70	Hold Line 66	Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 71-80	Hold Line 71	Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 81-90		Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 91-99	Hold Line 92	Vote: 9-0-0
Lines 101-110		Vote: 9-0-0

Lines 113-139 Hold Line 121
 Hold Line 123
 Hold Line 131 Vote: 9-0-0

Returning to each of the “held” Lines individually, the discussion and votes were:

Line 3	Prior vote was made to drop this line to \$0.	Vote: 9-0-0
Line 40	Fin Com is recommending a \$20,000 reduction. Rationale: other Town Departments were “level funded”	Vote: 9-0-0
Line 41	Prior vote was made to “level fund” at \$1455	Vote: 9-0-0
Line 47	Prior vote was made to drop this line to \$0.	Vote: 9-0-0
Line 66	Prior vote was made to “level fund” at \$800	Vote: 9-0-0
Line 71	Prior vote was made to “level fund” at \$375	Vote: 9-0-0
Line 92	Concern expressed that this is underfunded	Vote: 9-0-0
Line 121	Fin Com is recommending a \$10,000 increase Assessor’s information supports this increase	Vote: 9-0-0
Line 123	“contingent upon override”	Vote: 9-0-0
Line 131	Fin Com is recommending \$15,000	Vote: 9-0-0

After discussion and voting on the proposed FY17 budget, Aniko asked for clarification about a portion of the Expense Reports. She wanted to know about the “tax taking expense.” Joe B. explained that the new tax collector will use this money to enforce the collection process.

Planning ahead, the Committee needs to:

- * Discuss notes to be added to documents to be shared at Town Meeting.
- * Clarify talking points and strategies for Town Meeting. In particular, how to discuss Free Cash and the need for a Stabilization Fund. Who will speak about each point?
- * Review the Articles

Tom C. will check with Cheryl about the “drop dead date” for publication of the Town Report. He will also ask Cheryl for copies of the Articles. Tom plans to send possible footnotes to members for review prior to next meeting.

Next Meeting: May 3rd at 7:00 in Town Hall

Adjourned at 8:55

Respectfully submitted, Chevy Seney